Read This First: A Regime Theory of Joy

This article explains the theory behind M-ZRT and includes a practical session example

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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theory I developed independently that seeks to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. I propose that joy is not only a reward state, but an access regime: it appears when evaluative control is sufficiently reduced, and becomes stable only after a threshold of autonomous unfolding.

Importantly, the second contribution of this work is the proposal of a mechanistically grounded induction task for joy.

Before You Begin the Task

This task involves a shift in brain regime, from one in which comparison, anticipation, and evaluation dominate, to one in which optimization is temporarily suspended. As a result, simply engaging in a serious question about the protocol is already enough to move out of the target regime.

Constructing a hierarchy also recruits the opposite regime, because hierarchy necessarily depends on comparison. Asking "Which exercise should I do, and how often?" already moves the brain away from the intended regime.

Therefore, the protocol begins by treating every option as equally acceptable. Doing an exercise or not doing it, using a game or not using a game, starting now, or not doing it at all. Before anything else, no option needs to rank above another. Only then should the protocol begin.

Skipping the exercise is not a failure, but one of the acceptable outcomes.

Attempting to optimize recruits the very processes the task is designed to suspend.

Before beginning the task, it may help to say once: *"There is nothing to optimize here."* Saying it repeatedly to make the task more effective is itself an attempt at optimization, and therefore already shifts processing toward the opposite regime.

Regarding mental activity, it is advisable to avoid what strongly recruits optimization, especially imagined conversations.

Beyond that, it is generally preferable not to interfere with ongoing thoughts. Exercises that directly target thought processes are among the most difficult for beginners. If thoughts arise, they arise. Simply don’t treat them as instructions to be immediately followed.

You can even apply M-ZRT to the task itself. If the task is performed in a game, occasionally launch the game and immediately close it instead of beginning the session. At other times, let the cursor pass over the game's icon without selecting it. On some occasions, after moving the cursor onto the icon, wait five seconds before clicking. Briefly treat the task itself as having no particular function before beginning it. All those are exemples, and none are better than the others.

Ideal Requirements

Outdoors, most exercises become significantly harder because the everyday environment continuously recruits action planning.

A third-person game; an inventory with valuable items; a safe area without combat or quest. Most action RPGs (Diablo-like games) therefore provide it.

The following proposal is in front of a computer, listening to music.

Beginner Protocol

> **Do not spam the exercises. It is important to leave periods of normal gameplay between them.**

As stated earlier, every option is acceptable. Doing the exercise, not doing it, using a game, not using a game, starting now, starting later. Nothing needs to rank above anything else before you begin. It may require several attempts over a few days before having a significant transition.

Paragraph Fragments

Read a short paragraph with the sentences intentionally out of order, switch to an unrelated paragraph, or expose yourself to small unrelated fragments of text. Do not try to reconstruct the correct sequence. The interpretation does not occur. If it naturally emerges, switch to another paragraph. Sometimes switch before that point, sometimes a little after. There is no ideal moment.

The goal is to briefly interrupt narrative continuity without optimizing the timing of the interruption. Each fragment remains an isolated piece rather than becoming part of a coherent unfolding sequence.

Do the following ones one at a time. You can optionally listen to music while doing them.

Wide Vision

For a few seconds, allow attention to include more than the central point of focus. The primary object remains visible, but surrounding objects, colors, shapes, and movement are also allowed to remain present.

Another Possible Time

After seeing the current time, briefly imagine a different time appearing on the display instead 11:24 → 7:13

One-Word Drift

Look at an object. Let one unrelated word pass through.
Chair → moon Cursor → bird. The object and the word merely touch briefly in awareness. Because the word appears and disappears quickly, the exercise can be performed with almost no cognitive effort.

Object Without a Task

Briefly notice an object without immediately relating it to a use or purpose.

Wrong But Unknown

Briefly notice that something about the object seems wrong, without identifying what.

Not Quite What It Is

Look at an ordinary object and briefly experience it as not entirely matching its usual category. Then let the impression disappear.

This Doesn't Quite Fit

Look at an ordinary object. For a moment, let it seem slightly out of place. Do not explain why. Then continue normally.

Before Function (salience)

Briefly notice an object before its function becomes important. Then continue normally.

Clock as an Object

Briefly observe the clock itself, screen, watch, or phone display as a visible object rather than as a source of information.

Incomplete Caption

Looking at something, an internal description starts but remains unfinished. Example: *"This is a..."*

Functional to Incidental

Briefly look at one visual detail that is currently irrelevant to the action you are performing.

How does object-related exercises work?

Looking at an object rapidly recruits several optimization processes:

- *selecting its function,*
- *stabilizing its category,*
- *retrieving its associations,*
- *predicting what comes next,*
- *preparing an action,*
- *assigning its relative importance.*

These exercises briefly destabilize this automatic recruitment, temporarily lowering Z, increasing the odds of a regime shift. However, if the exercise is performed with analysis, anticipation, or verification of its effects, the brain automatically recruits another set of action policies, increasing Z instead.

Bonus for outdoor walking:

Building Before Place

Briefly notice a building before it becomes a destination, landmark, or shop.

Person Before Relevance

Briefly notice a passerby before they become someone to avoid, follow, or evaluate.

Street Without Route

For a moment, let the street simply be present before it becomes part of your route.

Sidewalk Before Walking

Briefly notice the sidewalk before it becomes something to walk on.

Different Side

For a moment, let both sides of the street seem equally acceptable. You do not need to cross. Then continue normally.

Wide Vision

For a few seconds, allow attention to include more than the central point of focus. The primary object remains visible, but surrounding objects, colors, shapes, and movement are also allowed to remain present.

Rational of the Task

In A Regime Theory of Joy, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant radiating sensation in the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This intensive phenomenology can in part rule out placebo or simple novelty effects.

Increased olfactory sensitivity may reflect greater engagement of the hippocampal system. If so, the hippocampus's role in contextual memory and associative processing could increase the richness and diversity of subjective experience, producing a wider range of positive "textures." In this state, colors may feel unusually vivid, almost like tasting candy, odors can evoke the feeling of entering a different world, and small shimmering objects may spontaneously elicit rich mental imagery.

This may explain why certain moments, especially during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are remembered as unique.

A common idea is that the environment created the feeling. Instead, the environment may have acted as an amplifier of an already accessible brain configuration.

In principle, that would imply that spending an indefinite time in such a positive state may be theoretically possible.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to the regime theory of joy, the primary bottleneck preventing joy is not a lack of reward or dopamine, but the increasing rigidity of learned causal chains. As we learn, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This accumulated rigidity is captured by the variable Z.

Z progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and reliable action, but one that is incompatible with the regime of ease associated with joy.

Imagine a desk with a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits an enormous network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is considered less valuable than a computer, so it is treated as more disposable. It is picked up in a particular way, used for writing while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual place, and often checked afterward to make sure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also tied to object categorization: a pencil is "just a pencil," a computer is valuable because of its many functions, and each object automatically recruits its expected meaning and use.

As learning accumulates, behavior becomes increasingly organized around local optimization. Each selected action automatically recruits the next preferred policy. M-ZRT (Minimal Z-reduction task) introduces small discontinuities into these chains before they fully stabilize.

Why M-ZRT Targets Optimization

Perception, thoughts, and actions naturally become organized around optimization. M-ZRT introduces brief perturbations that suspend this optimization before it recruits the next policy. Some tasks briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, and others leave sequences incomplete. Together, these small perturbations are proposed to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, making the ease regime more likely to emerge.

Each ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a framework that is deeply ingrained. This makes the task psychologically counterintuitive.

If it is approached too seriously, the brain naturally re-engages comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. At that point, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a joy-compatible state: It may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the exercise: **Alter Your Path**.

Normally, the player runs directly toward a destination. During the exercise *Alter Your Path*, the player introduces a small, purposeless deviation. They may change direction for a second or casually walk around an unimportant object before resuming their original route.

The primary activity is moving through the game world. Alter You Path is the disturbance. Beginners often find Alter Your Path surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an ongoing action sequence. What is interesting is that many people find it easier to perform a complicated task than to introduce a small arbitrary disruption into an action that is already underway. Some people will have less difficulty solving a puzzle or meditating than walking for two seconds in a slightly different direction.

With experience, however, even more advanced exercises become easier.

The system needs to learn that this is a valid behavioral pattern. Repeating the same exercise too rigidly continues the optimization process rather than relaxing it. Instead, the system must learn that behavior does not always need to be optimized.

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and used naturally, they may already have opened a brief episode of joy, or perhaps even the ease regime. You can find many other exercises that I have personally tested and validated:
florianmorin.com/assets/pdf/Morin2026-Joy-Requires-Reduced-Action-Coupling.pdf

They can be applied in a wide variety of contexts, and some target action mechanisms more directly and more aggressively. This makes it possible to modulate the intensity of the intervention more rapidly, and, depending on the situation, the intensity of joy itself, if you got the ease regime opened.

References:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318

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